

LONDON TOUR GUIDE ACTOR NORTH HAMPTON

Travel Radio Australia, we're at the Old Royal Naval College, and we're with Jonathan Coote, who is one of the guides here, and he knows all about it. Jonathan, welcome to the program. Nice to be able to chat to you about it, yeah.

Now, tell us about the Old Royal Naval College. It has such a tremendous history, doesn't it? Yeah, well, this whole site was originally, there was a Tudor palace, a bit like Hampton Court Palace, and this was instituted later. This was built by Christopher Wren, so on that same site, as a hospital for retired sailors by William and Mary, but the design is by Christopher Wren, and it's a fascinating place to visit.

Now, tell us a bit about the exhibits that are on display here. There's all sorts of really interesting stuff. Yeah, yeah.

Well, in Greenwich, we have the Maritime Museum as well, which has lots of artifacts and so forth. Here in the visitor center where we're chatting, we have lots of exhibits because our history stretches right back to Tudor times, so we have exhibits from the Tudor period, and then we have lots of exhibits about the architecture here. If you're interested in Christopher Wren and designs from that Baroque period, we have lots of material on that.

But also, after it was the hospital, it became the Royal Naval College, so we have lots of displays about the period in the Victorian through to the modern era, through the two World Wars, about its period as the Naval College, so there's lots here to see. And what is it these days? I believe it's a university now, and there's all sorts of things going on. We've got the University of Greenwich in here.

We also have Trinity Lab and Conservatoire of Music, so that's another little fringe bonus you get. If you're walking around the site, you hear music wafting out, sort of jazz, opera, all sorts of things. They also hold recitals in our chapel regularly, twice a week.

So yeah, there's a lot here to see and do. We're actually the Greenwich Foundation, so we're here to look after the Painted Hall, which is a magnificent Baroque masterpiece by James Thornhill, painted over 19 years, celebrating the Glorious Revolution, naval power, so that's a wonderful place to visit. And your background, you're an actor, and this must be a great help for you when you're showing people around and guiding them around the facility.

Well, it does help, because the Painted Hall is a big space, so making yourself heard in a space like that, it does help having some sort of experience in projection and stuff. But also, I get the added bonus that every now and then they ask me to do something specifically actor-related. For example, there's a room called the Nelson Room, which is where Nelson's body was prepared before it lay in state in the Painted Hall for three days after his death at Trafalgar.

And there's an audio experience in there, so I provide the voice for that. And at the moment, where we're sitting now, is the Chocolate Exhibition, and at the back of the Chocolate Exhibition is a recreation of an 18th-century chocolate house, which was based in Greenwich, and they asked me to write and record the audio in there. So when you walk in there, you can hear conversations between Christopher Wren, John Flamsteed, the first astronomer, John Evelyn, the diarist, and John Vanbrugh, the playwright, having a chat over a dish of chocolate.

And it's got a really good cast, who I managed to pull in friends of mine, like Malcolm Sinclair, who you've probably seen in the Casino Royale and various other movies and theatre productions. Now, there's one display here that I believe is actual, the jacket that Nelson was shot in, and you can still see the bullet holes. Yeah, yeah.

Unfortunately, we used to have that here. We also used to have the funeral car, which they used to transport his body from here to St. Paul's. But those artefacts are kept now at the Maritime Museum, including some magnificent naval art that we used to have here on display in the Painted Hall.

There was a few other Nelson artefacts that we used to have here, and there's actually a story about a famous theft, robbery that happened when we were still, I'm not sure if it was the college or the hospital, some people broke in and stole some of these Nelson artefacts. It was a real heist story. And what are some of the highlights for you? What is your absolute favourite display here, or a couple of them? Well, a couple.

Well, the chocolate house, obviously, from personal investment, I'm really proud of that. But I do like the Painted Hall. As a work of art, it's amazing, as an example of history, because it covers various monarchs.

But if you're interested in astronomy, there's stuff there about constellations and famous astronomers, Galileo, Tycho Brahe, the Danish astronomer. We also do a lot of film tours here as well. And obviously, I enjoy doing those, because this is possibly the most famous and most popular film location, according to Empire Magazine, in the world.

We've been photographed more than the Hollywood sign, apparently. What have we had here? Four weddings and a funeral in the chapel, two James Bond movies, Thor, Doctor Strange, but also classic movies like Les Misérables, The Musical, period things like Ridley Scott's Napoleon. If you watch Napoleon by Ridley Scott, it's like looking at a home movie of the Royal Naval College.

It's extraordinary. And it's amazingly malleable. So it can be St. Petersburg, it can be Berlin, it can be Paris.

It's just a really malleable location for all sorts of filmmakers. And of course, right next door, you have the Greenwich Mean Time exhibition. And that is great, too.

Yeah, yeah. The observatory just up the hill. First occupant was John Flamsteed, whose voice appears in the Chocolate House exhibition.

But yeah, you can go up and see the Meridian Line and lots of exhibits about its history as the observatory. And one of my relatives, which is John Harrison's clock. And that's what the whole GMT is based around.

Funny we should be talking about like this. But I have an ancestor who was associated with that whole period as well. Because my ancestors include the Valimys, the clockmakers, and Domaine Bray, who was the astronomer who was based out in Richmond and did the observation of the transit of Venus for George III.

So funny we should be talking together like this. But I think our ancestors may have met. For those who don't know, John Harrison created the clock, which you put into ships, which floated and kept the most exact time you could possibly have.

Exactly. It's a whole thing with Greenwich Mean Time. Yeah, absolutely.

Harrison is a very famous name in the history of our site and Greenwich as a whole. The last couple of years, we've had an exhibition by Luke Jerram, who's an artist, but he recreates the world and the moon. We've had that exhibited in our painted hall, which is an amazing site because it's a huge exhibit.

And later this year, we're having Mars, which is the third of his kind trilogy. And also next year, 2025, we're having our 100th anniversary, the first film that was ever shot here, which is a black and white, obviously silent movie called Sons of the Sea. So we're celebrating all our history of filmmaking here, right back to there, and including all those movies I've already explained to you.

Well, Jonathan Coote, thank you very much for being with us on Travel Radio Australia and for showing us around the magnificent old Naval College. And to all of our Australian listeners out there, come here. And do you have to pay to get in? How does that work? Yeah, if you want to visit the painted hall, there's a fee for that, there's a charge to enter.

But if you just want to come and look at the little museum here with our chocolate house exhibition, which is here until, well, November, but maybe extended into March, that's a very cheap little three pound entry for there. But the 16.50 for the whole site. Jonathan, how can people find out more about the old Naval College here online? You have a website? Yeah, we have a website for the old Royal Naval College.

If you just put in Old Royal Naval College, or ORNC, you'll be able to find lots of information there about all the forthcoming events. Wonderful. Thank you, Jonathan, for being with us.

Absolute pleasure. Nice to meet you. While in London, I travelled to Bermondsey in South

London and caught up with a real actor, Paul Wilde, who happens to be disabled, but uses his condition to further his acting career to great effect.

Travel Radio Australia, and we're in South London at the moment, in a place called Bermondsey, which is very traditional South London. And I have one of the locals here who is esteemed UK actor Paul Wilde, and he is a real, real local of Bermondsey. And Paul, welcome to the programme.

Hello. Great, great to see you. Now, Paul, you're very well connected with the area around here.

And the history is incredible. It's South London. You've been involved in the area for quite some time.

Tell us a bit about your background. Yeah, I moved up here from Southampton to London to follow my dream of being an actor. And I landed here in Bermondsey.

And I love it. I'll be moving soon. But I love it here.

The people are so real, you know, and so easy to get on with. And it's such a such a cool place to live. It's been described as a village, really, isn't it in the middle of London? Well, everywhere was originally a village.

And that that has just grown. I mean, London itself started off as a little hamlet by the river. And, and they just grow into each other, like Peckham was a village, Bermondsey, and now they've kind of meet on the old Kent Road.

So a lot of that mentality stays the same, you know, people are, I'm Bermondsey boy, or I'm a Peckhamite, you know, and they are close and they're real. And it is good to see that in a city like London, that sort of thing still exists. Now, you're an actor, professional actor, and you have a disability as well.

You lost your leg a little while ago. And tell us about that. And, and I, I've got to know you pretty well over the last week or so.

And I, I think it's gives you a fantastic uniqueness as an actor. And that's certainly sometimes it's helped you along the way, hasn't it? Yes, I'm still waiting for my James Bond baddie audition. I haven't got that yet, perhaps because I haven't got a cat.

But it does. I have a prosthetic I can use. So I can I can take roles that are walking or in a wheelchair or showing a prosthetic.

So it does give me a wider range than when I was just acting normally with just two legs. So So yeah, it's kind of in a funny way helped help my career. Yeah.

So tell us about this movie you've recently started. Is it the dance movie? Tell us a bit about that.

Yeah, it's a movie called The Broken Arrow.

We just had a premiere of it and which is very well received. So it's about the game of darts, which is very popular here in England. So the premise is famous darts player on the rise through his career.

But he's a bit of a nasty fellow and as a gets drunk, wins a cup, falls asleep with a cup in his hand on a freezing night, ends up having his arm amputated, not his throwing arm. And he's all depressed and trying to earn money, conning people, going out to pubs like that. You want to go with darts? I'm an ex armed forces, lost me arm in the forces.

Oh, yeah, here we go. So he's, you know, conning people out of money. And then I hear about the Olympic Games having darts involved, you know, and there's a scene where they use darts.

So it's a game. It's the Olympic Games. They said, OK, well, then we'll include it then.

It'll go away after that, just like synchronized swimming. So he tries out for the Paralympic darts team and has to beat his nemesis, who is the best Paralympic darts player or Paralympian in that particular sport. And so he goes about trying to beat him and I play his nemesis.

So I have a wheelchair and it's done like a spaceship and I have an oxygen tank and a breathing mask. So I'm. And my name is Darts Vader in the film, and it's hilarious and it's a good old British comedy like they used to make.

Yeah, absolutely brilliant. Now, you were telling me recently you took a world trip, you know, to America and and tell us a bit about that and some of your experiences. Well, I was I was doing a play last year and it was touring the country and I was going from London up to Wales, up to Manchester, to Malcolm and all over the place.

And it just dawned on me. I thought, well, if I can do this in my wheelchair, why can't I go anywhere in my wheelchair? And so I thought I've always wanted to travel across the States. And so I got together with a travel agent who organized all my stuff.

And I literally went from London Waterloo down to Southampton, where I come from. And it was nice to leave my own town on a Queen Mary and see as we leave the docks, looking at all the old places, you get a lovely view. And enough, I went to New York and from New York, I went up to Canada, where I visited Niagara Falls and went out in the little boat.

From there, I came back to New York, then went to Chicago, where I met my travel agent. She lives there. I stayed in Chicago for a few days.

It's my favorite town. It's a brilliant place. And then I went on the Amtrak all the way in my own little sleeper, all the way across to San Francisco, through the Colorados and everything.

And it was so beautiful. And then I went to Alcatraz in San Francisco, and I flew back. And if anybody's really interested, you can go to my YouTube channel, Paul Wilde, and you can follow my journey.

I blogged it in various stages. And you can watch how I coped with different difficulties and different issues that arise for people in my situation. Nothing is insurmountable.

If someone with one leg can do the whole world, I mean, what's holding everyone back? I mean, it's real life, isn't it? It's great. And I'm sure that you had some unusual and funny experiences along the way. Do you have any anecdotes that you could let us know about? Well, the unusual, sad, and funny was the train I got from New York to Canada was fairly busy.

And my seat, disabled seat, was the wheelchair, I think. It wasn't a sleeper, because it was a one-day short through New York state. Whereas Amtrak, I had my own sleeper and toilet and everything.

Here, I was just with a normal disabled toilet in the carriage. And nobody used the normal toilet. They all used the disabled toilet.

And that's that. And of course, the sinks start getting blocked up with toilet paper. And the toilet does, and the floor does, and it becomes unusable.

And I've put this in my blog, because I thought I was getting quite indignant. How can these people? And then I took a picture of it. And I took a picture of the normal toilet, and it had a tiny little piece of paper on the floor, you could barely see.

And I thought, this is crazy. So I made my concerns known to the train company. And on the way back, the journey back, I had this guard sitting next to me, guarding the disabled toilet for me.

And he was fantastic, because he'd done the journey so often. He knew everything about every step of the Hudson River that you follow, all the history of the different stops, you know, the buildings, the derelict buildings, what they were. And so I got this amazing travel guide with me, who was also guarding the disabled toilet for me.

So the journey back was fine. But the journey there was frantic going to Niagara, yes. That's funny.

Little things like that occur, you know, that you forget about. But I did put that, it's in my blog, and a few little things like that, you know, a few issues that I have. I didn't have too many issues, generally pretty good.

And a couple of highlights? Highlights being how, whatever train station we pulled into Amtrak, they have these red caps, they wear like red berries. And so you can see them, and they're there to help you. And they take every bit of strain off of you, because they're so good, you know.

My major sightseeing highlight had to be Alcatraz, because it's always a place I've wanted to visit. And you go over there, and you actually see how small it is. It's mind-blowing.

It really is a small place. The cells are small. The canteen's small.

The reception area is small. Everything is so tight and compact. And you visit the cells of real ex-criminals, you know, and the story.

And you can really get a good vibe from the place of what it must have been like. Because, yeah, very claustrophobic place, but a joy to visit. And of course, going back to and from the island is a fantastic trip.

And I met this guy in a bar in San Francisco. And he'd actually swum from Alcatraz to San Francisco, which is dangerous to do. But he does it.

Oh, there's sharks and everything. Absolutely. Tides, cold water, and he does it.

And I said to him, so how long does it take you to swim to Alcatraz? He said, Paul, nobody swims to Alcatraz. You only swim away from it. If you're lucky.

If you don't get dashed on the rocks or whatever. It can be done because people have found out how to do it these days and where the tides go. And so it's swimmable now.

And it was nice to meet somebody who actually swam it. So that was a highlight in San Francisco. Yeah, it was good.

The whole thing was real buzz, just doing what I was doing. And like I say, what's stopping everybody else? Well, it's not your disability physically, it's your disability mentally, because that's what holds anybody back from doing and trying anything. So yeah, it was good.

And as I said, if you want to follow the blog, the travel blog, it's on my YouTube channel, Paul Wild. Brilliant, Paul, thank you very much for being with us on Travel Radio Australia, fascinating stories. And yeah, we'll be following you and your blogs and your movie journeys in the future.

And we'll catch up with you again for some more insights about London and, and everything in the entertainment world of the UK. Oh, please do, please do. And pleasure to meet you, Jeff.

Thank you. Paul Wild, check him out on YouTube. And he has various other links, Paul Wild Actor, that's W-I-L-D and fascinating stuff.

After London, it was time to head north to the picturesque North Midlands County of Northamptonshire, where I caught up with some of the locals. Travel Radio Australia, and we're in the Northampton area of England this month. And I have with me Andy Roberts.

And Andy, can you tell us a bit about your title and what you do? Yeah, so say Andy Roberts, I'm

a tourism officer for West Northamptonshire Council, obviously tasked with improving the visitor economy for Northampton and the surrounding area. This area is a wonderful place. It's very close to London, it's only an hour or so drive or an hour and a half drive and very easy to get to if you are coming to London on the train.

And tell us about some of the things you can do and see in the area. Yeah, we are we think Northampton and the wider county is a bit of a hidden gem, really, and you say an hour from London and location is probably one of our key strengths here in terms of people visiting the UK and that we're an hour from London and Birmingham, Oxford, Cambridge, Stratford, a good base to come and explore. But there's a lot to see and do here in its own right, really.

My job is to try and, you know, enhance the tourism offer for visitors and locals alike, to be fair. And just as an example, we have what I consider several key strengths to Northampton in terms of the offer we can offer around the town's history and heritage, certainly the town's sporting offer, the green space and the blue space of the canals and the waterside, not least the town and areas shoe industry, which is world famous, which we probably don't shout about often and long enough. But that's certainly something worth coming here to explore.

And we have a good cultural base as well. So there are several good strong elements to Northampton. We probably don't shout too loud about it.

We need to be shouting louder. And hopefully that's what we can do in the near future. I noticed there's some really interesting things you can visit.

One of the ones was the Spencer Lady Diana grave area is very close here, isn't it? It is. I mean, Lady Di, as she's known, obviously, is buried on an island at the Allthorpe Estate, which is a few miles out of Northampton. So that's very close at hand.

I expect another iconic venue that we have in the county is Silverstone Motor Racing Circuit, the home of Formula One, really. We've just had the Grand Prix and Silverstone again is only a few miles out of Northampton towards Milton Keynes. So there are two big attractions, really.

I expect the county is traditionally known for its historic houses and the vast array of historic houses and gentry who still live in this in this county. Allthorpe obviously is to the fore. But we also have Solgrave Manor, which is the ancestral home of George Washington.

It's something slightly a little bit different is there is also an Australian connection and one of the cemeteries in Northampton, really, where a Northampton woman born in Northampton and also buried in Northampton, but best known for her work as a social reformer, really, in Australia, Caroline Chisholm. And she has a grave in the town. Again, you know, that's something people are very interested in when they come and visit here.

Yes, certainly. We have a university named after her in Melbourne and Chisholm campus there.

So she is very well known in Australia and especially in Melbourne, the town itself.

I've been spending about a week here and it's very easy to get around. Lovely. There's beautiful church in town.

Tell us about that. There are several beautiful churches. I know I'm biased, but I think there are.

Yeah, there are some lovely churches really throughout the county, but certainly in Northampton town centre where we have right in the middle of the town is the the All Saints Church, which is a sort of a portico style church with a little cafe right in the heart of Northampton. Just a short walk away is the Church of the Holy Sepulchre, one of only four round churches in England in terms of its design and based on the the original Church of the Holy Sepulchre in Jerusalem, a really interesting building. And also, funnily enough, I had a call today from a lady who's taking over a restaurant in a church, the Church of St John, again, one of the principal town churches, which has been transformed into a very atmospheric and interesting restaurant to visit.

And I noticed staying here for a week, I got the very easy to buy stagecoach pass, which is like £23 a week, gives you unlimited transport, which is very handy too. Absolutely. Yes.

I mean, in fairness, Jeff, I'm in public transport in Northampton and in the country generally is a bit of a bone of contention because most people think it could be better, certainly compared to, I'm not sure the situation in Australia, but certainly compared to Europe. But yeah, there are certainly still some very good deals to get on the buses. The trains are quite expensive, it has to be said, but buses do offer good value on the whole.

Tell us a bit more about the Silverstone race experience. That sounds great. Yes.

I mean, a few years ago now, the Silverstone circuit has really grown and amplified itself, I expect, in recent years. And as part of that, they've opened what they call the Silverstone Museum, which is an experience for the whole family to come along and learn, obviously, about the history of the British Grand Prix and Formula One generally, and the history of motorsport and, you know, the old cars and the old gear that they used to wear. And it's a very interactive experience.

It's called the Silverstone Museum, so say it's based next to the circuit, it's a great day out for families. So if you are in this area and looking to test your motorsport skills, that's certainly a place you need to go to. And I believe there's a simulator there, too, where you can just jump into and act like you really are Lewis Hamilton or someone like that.

Yeah, absolutely. You know, it's a really fantastic place, a great addition to our offer, really. Yeah, you can wave a chequered flag and you can time yourself and you can change a tyre in the pit lane and what have you and see how quick you are.

So for kids especially, it's brilliant. And what's one of your favourite go-to places? I expect,

because I'm of a certain age now, I'm getting to appreciate the the countryside, really. Again, we have some beautiful countryside in Northamptonshire, certainly in the south of the county, which takes on a Cotswolds feel.

And they say it's a bit like the Cotswolds, but without the traffic and the people, really. Some beautiful villages. And I expect one of my favourite areas is a little place called Forsley, which is near the town of Daventry.

A beautiful, green, rolling landscape, very tranquil, very peaceful place, which hasn't changed really over the years. Designed by Capability Brown. It's got one hotel and one little restaurant, but the rest is just sheep and beauty, really.

So that's my go-to place just to chill out. Sounds wonderful. Well, thanks very much for telling us all about the wonderful area of Northampton and indeed Northamptonshire.

Is it a county or...? It is, yes. Again, just finally, Northamptonshire, they have a cricket team. Played Australia a few times over the years.

Not to great success, but obviously a good sports base in the town as well with football. And not least, we've got to get this in, the English champions of rugby, Northampton Saints. And you have a really nice stadium here too.

Tell us a bit about that. Yeah, that would be the Saints Stadium, I think you refer to, which is a great rugby venue. It's one of the venues for the Women's Rugby World Cup next year.

So if anyone's coming over, do visit Northampton on your travels as part of that and see the sites. Yeah, so that's a top class facility. We're very proud of our rugby team.

And Andy, how can people find out more about Northamptonshire in general online? Yeah, I mean, we're in the process of obviously, through the local authority here, getting a greater online presence. But I think the best, there are two go-tos I expect online. If you search Discover Northamptonshire, it's a website dedicated to what's on around the wider county.

And also there's something called Northamptonshire's Best Surprise, which if you, that brings up all the attractions we have here and all the information about when they're open and what there is to do and see. So Discover Northamptonshire or Northamptonshire's Big Surprise. Andy Roberts, thank you very much for being with us on Travel Radio Australia.

Pleasure. Many thanks for sparing me a time to talk about Northamptonshire. Thank you.

Travel Radio Australia. We're here in the middle of Northampton city and we're at a very interesting place called the Eccentric Englishman, which is an incredible place. It's a bit of a fairyland, Alice in Wonderland sort of place.

I have the owners here. Can you introduce yourselves for us? I'm Liz, aka Lady Mook. And I'm Mooker, aka Lord Mook.

Great. Now tell us a bit about the Eccentric Englishman and what happens here? We do all sorts of things. Our main thing is cheesecakes.

That's what we're known for. And also tiddly teas, which is alcoholic afternoon teas with teapot cocktails. Can I notice here, you're dressed up in your regalia here.

I wish this was TV because you've got the fabulous beard and you've got all this. Well, how would you describe it, your look? Well, the idea is to be literally an eccentric Englishman. Unfortunately, I've turned into more of a prop sitting at the bar for the customers to shake hands and have photographs taken with.

But there you go. Everyone's got their cross to bear. Now you're very much a fixture here in Northampton.

A lot of people come to you and tell us a bit about the events and how they work. Well, I'm going to pass you over to Lady Mook because she does all the events. Yeah, as I said, he's the prop, so I just make him sit there and look pretty.

We'll try. But what we do, we do all sorts of things. We do themed bottomless brunch quizzes, so Friends, The Wizard of Oz, Harry Potter.

We also do themed afternoon teas, so Harry Potter, Alice in Wonderland. We've got a Family Fortunes coming up. Lots of psychic nights, Murder Mysteries.

Yeah, lots of different things. Yeah, always something going on. And I noticed the interior.

You've spent a hell of a lot of work on the interior. Tell us a bit about it. We're always changing.

When we first opened the plant, we had two houses full, van full, two sheds full. When we got it in, it still didn't cover anywhere near it, did it? But we're constantly looking. We also advertise local artists.

We get things given to us from people who want something to go to a good home. So, yeah, we look after things for nearest and dearest of people. And we're always on the lookout for new things.

There's still room on the walls. Some of your favourite things? Oh, some of my favourite stuff. Well, basically, most of the stuff in there is what they call an eclectic mix, which is all the junk out of my sheds and my house.

When you walk in, it really is like walking into Narnia. Narnia, I'd say. Yes, like that.

Bit like Narnia. Love a bit of Narnia. How long did it take you? When did you first start it off? Well, coming up to three years.

The initial idea came up in lockdown. We were looking at things in bigger cities we don't find in our hometown. So we created something.

It was a gamble. And so far it's worked out. Yeah, it's wonderful.

It's right here in the main street next to the Optimist pub. Tell us a bit about your website. How can people find out more about the Eccentric Englishman online? It's all on www.theeccentricenglishman.co.uk. Also on our Facebook page as well, where the events are going up to October on that one.

On the website, there's the next month you can find about cakes we do, events we do, menus are all on there, the history. There's a little blog about the two of us on there as well. So lots of stuff.

Thank you very much. And Instagram as well. I'm very tourist friendly.

Oh, yes. I've been made very welcome here. And it's a very magical place.

And I highly recommend the Eccentric Englishman to all of our Australian friends. Give us a shout out to people in Australia. Hello to everyone in Australia.

We've had quite a few of you in. So we're very welcoming. We'd love to see more of you.

God love the Aussies. Thank you, guys. Have a great day.

Thank you. Cheers. Well, that's about it for this time.

We hope you've enjoyed our journey through London and Northamptonshire on Travel Radio Australia. Next month, we'll be sampling the delights of Amsterdam and Europe.